

Exporting the Employee's Google Workspace Data to Your Computer

This guide exports the **Google Drive files and Gmail** of specific employees onto your own computer, so you can hand the data over. Here is the whole process and *why* each step exists — every step is explained in full detail in the pages that follow.

Reference: <https://github.com/data847/workspace-classifier>

Major step	Why it's needed
1. Create a Google "service account"	Gives the tool its own secure, read-only login, so it can read the data without needing anyone's password.
2. Turn on 3 Google services (Drive, Gmail, Admin SDK)	Opens only the specific "doors" the tool needs to reach the files and mail.
3. Approve the service account as admin	You, the administrator, authorize exactly what it may read. Nothing works until you do this.
4. Install the tool on your computer	It's a small program that runs locally, so the data never leaves your machine.
5. Choose the employees & time period	You decide whose data, and which dates, get exported.
6. Run the export	Download the chosen Drive files and Gmail into a folder on your computer.
7. Verify, zip, and send	Confirm it's complete, compress it, and hand it over securely.

Steps 1–3 happen on Google's websites (clicking). Steps 4–6 happen in a terminal on your computer. Step 7 is on your computer too.

Who does what

- **You (the operator)** must be signed in as a **super administrator** of your Google Workspace (as the CEO/owner, you typically are).
- **One account is involved:** a **Google** account that reads the data. The exported files stay on **your computer** the whole time.

The whole thing in 4 stages

1. **Google Cloud** — create a "service account" that's allowed to read the data.
2. **Google Admin** — approve that service account (you're the admin).
3. **Your computer** — install the tool, choose the employees and time period, and run it.
4. **Find the data and hand it off** — confirm it saved, zip it, and send it.

Stage 1 — Google Cloud: create the “service account”

A *service account* is just a login for software instead of a person that will read the files. You create it in Google’s developer console.

Reference: <https://developers.google.com/workspace/guides/create-credentials>

Steps:

1. Go to <https://console.cloud.google.com/> and sign in with your admin account.
2. At the top, click the project dropdown → **New Project**. Name it something like **Workspace Export**. Click **Create**, then make sure that project is selected.
3. Turn on the tools the export needs. Go to **APIs & Services** → **Library**, and for each of these, search its name and click **Enable**: **Google Drive API**, **Gmail API**, **Calendar**, **Chat** and **Admin SDK API**.
4. Create the service account. **Go to IAM & Admin** → **Service Accounts** → **Create service account**. Give it a name like workspace-export. Click **Create and continue**, then **Done** (skip the optional screens).
5. Make its key file. Click the service account → **Keys** tab → **Add key** → **Create new key** → **JSON** → **Create**. A file downloads. **Rename it to exactly service_account.json** and remember where it is. Treat this file like a password.
6. Get the service account ID number. **Open the service account** → **Show advanced settings** (or the **Details** tab) → **copy the “Client ID”** (a long number). Keep it handy for Stage 2.

Stage 2 — Google Admin: approve the service account

The service account can’t read anyone’s data until an admin approves it. You do this in the separate **Google Admin** console.

Steps (signed in as a super admin):

1. Go to <https://admin.google.com/>.
2. Navigate to: **Security** → **Access and data control** → **API controls** → **Manage Domain-Wide Delegation**.
3. Click **Add new**.
4. In **Client ID**, paste the number you copied in Stage 1, Step 6.
5. In **OAuth scopes**, paste this exact text (these are the read-only permissions the tool needs). Paste it as one continuous line with no spaces:

```
https://www.googleapis.com/auth/drive.readonly,https://www.googleapis.com/auth/gmail.readonly,https://www.googleapis.com/auth/admin.directory.user.readonly,https://www.googleapis.com/auth/calendar.readonly
```

6. Click **Authorize**.

Stage 3 — Your computer: install, choose, and run

This part uses the **terminal** to install the tool and to choose the employees and the time period.

- **Mac:** open the app called **Terminal** (press Cmd+Space, type “Terminal”, press Enter).
- **Windows:** install Python first (below), then open **PowerShell** from the Start menu.

Step 1 — Install the basics from the official sites:

- **Python** (version 3.10 or newer) — from **python.org**. On Windows, tick “Add Python to PATH” during install.
- **Git** — from **git-scm.com**.

Step 2 — Check Python is there. In the terminal, type this and press Enter:

```
python3 --version
```

You should see a number like 3.11.x. (On Windows you may need to type `python --version`.)

Step 3 — Download the tool and its parts. Type these lines one at a time:

```
git clone https://github.com/data847/workspace-classifier.git
```

```
cd workspace-classifier
```

```
python3 -m pip install -r requirements.txt
```

Step 4 — Put the Google key file in place. Move the `service_account.json` file from Stage 1 into this `workspace-classifier` folder.

Step 5 — Create the settings file. Type:

```
cp .env.example .env  
open -e .env
```

Then open the new `.env` file in a plain text editor and make sure it contains just this one line (no AWS or AI keys are needed for a local export):

```
GOOGLE_SERVICE_ACCOUNT_FILE=service_account.json
```

Save the file.

Step 6 — Choose the employees and the time period

This is the part you’ll change to fit the request. You build one command by combining a “who” piece and (optionally) a “when” piece from this table:

What you want	What to add to the command
One employee	<code>--user employee@yourcompany.com</code>
Several specific employees	<code>--only alice@yourcompany.com --only bob@yourcompany.com</code> (repeat <code>--only</code> for each)
Everything (all time)	(add nothing extra)
Only the last N days	<code>--since-days 90</code> (example: last 90 days)
Everything since a start date	<code>--modified-after 2024-01-01</code>

About time periods: the tool can do “last N days” or “everything since a start date,” but it cannot filter to a closed window with both a start and an end date (there is no “before this date” option). If you need, say, only a specific past quarter, export from that start date and trim the extra afterward — or ask your provider to do the trimming.

Step 7 — Run it

Replace the emails with the real ones.

Example — one employee, everything:

```
python3 run_org_classify.py \
  --admin ceo@yourcompany.com \
  --user employee@yourcompany.com \
  --export-only \
  --local-only
```

Example — two employees, only since 1 January 2024:

```
python3 run_org_classify.py \
  --admin ceo@yourcompany.com \
  --only alice@yourcompany.com \
  --only bob@yourcompany.com \
  --export-only \
  --local-only \
  --modified-after 2024-01-01
```

Example — one employee, only the last 90 days:

```
python3 run_org_classify.py \
  --admin ceo@yourcompany.com \
  --user employee@yourcompany.com \
  --export-only \
  --local-only \
  --since-days 90
```

- This grabs **both Drive files and Gmail** automatically. It can run for a while and you can leave it going. Nothing is uploaded anywhere; everything is saved on this computer. **If it stops or the computer sleeps, just run the exact same command again** — it picks up where it left off.

Stage 4 — Find the data and hand it off

Step 1 — Find it. Inside the `workspace-classifier` folder there's now an `out` folder. Each employee has their own subfolder containing:

- `dump/files/` — their Drive files (original folder structure kept)
- `dump/emails/` — their Gmail: a full `emails_all.json`, a simple `emails_metadata.csv` you can open in Excel, the individual message texts, and an `attachments` folder

Open a couple of these to confirm real content is there.

Step 2 — Zip it up.

- **Mac:** in the terminal, from inside the `workspace-classifier` folder, type: `zip -r workspace-export.zip out`
- **Windows:** in File Explorer, right-click the `out` folder → **Send to** → **Compressed (zipped) folder**.

Step 3 — Send it to your provider.

Step 4 — Clean up when done. After your provider confirms they have everything:

- Delete the `service_account.json` file and the `out` folder / zip from the computer.
- Optionally remove the service account's authorization in the Google Admin console (Stage 2) and delete the service account in Google Cloud.

Where people get stuck (and when to grab help)

The website stages (1 and 2) are click-only and most people can follow them with the official screenshots open in another tab. **Stage 3 (the terminal) is a little technical part.** Some common errors:

Problem	What to do
"Permission denied" / 403 errors from Google	Re-check Stage 2 — the Client ID and the full scopes text must be pasted exactly. Wait a few minutes and try again.
Errors listing or finding the employee	Check the email is spelled correctly and the <code>--admin</code> account is a super administrator .
<code>python3: command not found</code>	Python isn't installed or not on PATH — reinstall from python.org (Windows: tick "Add to PATH"), or try <code>python</code> instead of <code>python3</code> .
It stopped partway	Just run the same command again — it resumes where it left off.
Nothing in the out folder	The time filter may be too narrow, or the employee has little data in that range. Try without <code>--since-days</code> / <code>--modified-after</code> .

All Google access here is **read-only** — nothing in your Workspace is changed or deleted. The exported data stays entirely on your computer. Nothing is sent to any outside service until you choose to share the zip in Stage 4.